



Symfony, NetBeans, XAMPP

The Perfect Trio for PHP Web App Development

This article describes the 'perfect' environment for developing Web applications in PHP on the Windows platform (though the software is also available on Linux).

One of the most difficult situations developers face is choosing the perfect environment for application development. It's even tougher with open source tools; there may be glitches in the software you choose, and there are chances that midway through application development, you realise you're stuck and cannot proceed. The only way to minimise such risks is to carefully choose tried and tested tools, with robust community support. Here we will discuss such an environment, on the Windows platform—the NetBeans IDE, the Symfony framework and the XAMPP Web server package.

The framework

A framework is designed to provide basic application functionality such as database interaction, form validation and presentation. With these available, you can focus on writing application code. Also, the less code you write, the fewer bugs you introduce. Our framework here is Symfony—one of the most-used PHP frameworks, with great community support and some prestigious references like Drupal, phpBB, Opensky.com, etc.

You can download version 1.4.17 or 2.0 from the website (<http://goo.gl/YiUer>); the information there will help you decide which to use. A common

difficulty in using Symfony is that it's hard to learn its commands and file structure. Also, its commands must be run using a command prompt. However, as we will see, using the NetBeans IDE reduces these problems to a large extent. Symfony does not need installation—just unzip the downloaded zip file, and in the IDE section, we can integrate it with NetBeans.

The Web server/database

XAMPP is a bundle of Apache, MySQL and PHP, which we will be using for our development environment. It is completely